and clubbed them in categories of geographic continuities. Opening the book, you have a series of stunning images which move onto full-page spreads of vernacular architecture sourced from tribal huts of western India to Buddhist monuments, giving the feeling that one is holding a coffee-table book. Far from it, it is an amazing source book on ordinary India's unsung masterpieces of vernacular architecture. The author goes on to present in stunning images, the delicate sensibilities of appropriate architecture along with outstanding craftsmanship, not under royal or religious patronage but under ordinary folk. That a society which had integrated the pinnacle of craftsmanship and colour sensibilities with the everyday is demonstrated here page after page, raising the respect for the genius of ordinary India. He covers the country as geographic zones. The southern states are clubbed here almost as a stylistic continuum. With parts of the images drawn from museums and occasional geography-hopping, the south India section deserved a more exhaustive and clear coverage even at the risk of a multiplying cell-division to one more volume. The unique materials, the attention to detail and capturing of interiors, street-building interfaces and even at times the focus on indigenous lived-in interiors are truly a treat for the reader.

Under a chapter head of 'Related Structures', an array of immaculately photographed stepped wells, baths and water systems are featured, doing full justice to the structures covered. Here, one is also reminded of the seamlessly interlinked relationships of materials, structure and design, which itself yields an aesthetic: true peaks in design that at once surpass the architecture and craftsmanship to a paradoxical minimalism.

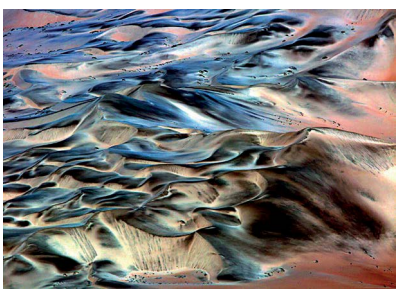
Unique materials, capturing of interiors, street-building interfaces and focus on indigenous lived-in interiors are a treat for readers

The section on the Northeast is devoted to tribal houses with some stunning images of the most unusual buildings in hay, thatch, bamboo and other ephemeral materials. Sustainability is here elevated to an aesthetic, simultaneously embodying the specificities of community symbols through signs. This section surprisingly hops across to the Andamans and even the Lakshadweep islands. Lakshadweep is at best represented as a variation on Kerala's domestic architecture and the Andamans displays an entirely different historic and ethnic lineage.

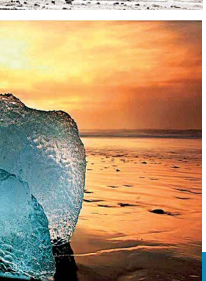
The penultimate chapter explores the futures of knowledge systems that may find resonance in contemporary practices. The author quotes a few examples to reiterate that, apart from being a fine cultural product, vernacular architecture is an instrument of dissent against unsustainable Modernism. In the last chapter, the author moves to Eurasian hybridities in architecture. In fabulous images of bungalows, havelis and other residential typologies, the author demonstrates how social and climatic adaptations of two very different cultures have culminated in altogether new expressions. Goa has one of the best image representations in this section of the book.

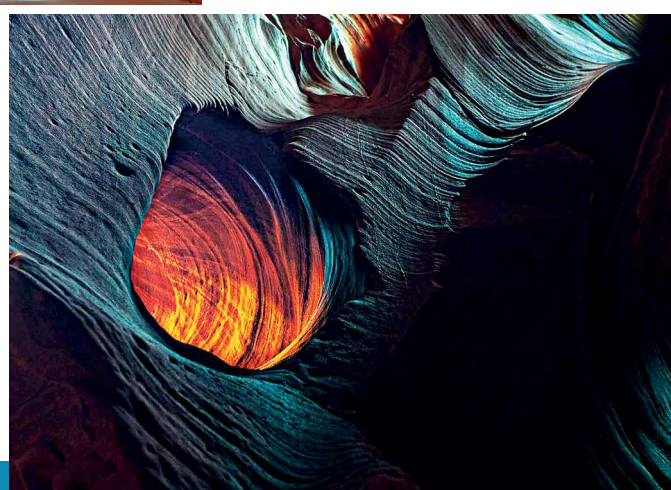
In its production value, this book is one of the finest to come out in recent times on this subject. Every page can kindle new hope in the reader/viewer regarding India's unmatched creativity. Go for it, it's worth a read! ■

–K.T. Ravindran









LANDSCAPE LOVE
(Left) Namib Desert, 2015; (below and below left) Antelope Canyon, 2019 and (bottom) Iceland, 2010

the three locations. Sakhuja pours a disarming honesty and unalloyed colour into the description of his experience and connect with the geography.

Reading that is like getting a lens implant in the mind. Our fleeting eyes slow down and we begin to 'see' the book through the kindred eyes of the photographer.

The curtain of familiarity opens to reveal the intimate magic of light: remarkable juxtapositions of warm and cold light in the sandstone folds; the underside of a lone rock mysteriously glowing in a dark landscape, almost like enlightenment; a larger block of ice opening its embrace to offer a heart-shaped ice crystal; a frigid landscape awash with a molten sunrise spilling over the peaks; an aerial view of a desert made fluid like waves of ocean surf; a morning silhouette of mountains trapping within it a sandstorm catching light in a golden mist—the book is now visible, and the focus correction procedure successful. ■

–Bandeep Singh